look for Akbar when he was skipping school yet again found the prince sleeping with a ‘lustrous countenance’, talking with ‘the holy ones of heaven’s court’, his hands moving as if in a contemplative trance, and speaking: ‘God willing, I’ll bring the cream of earth’s surface under my sway and fulfil the desires of the sorrowful of the seven climes.’ Evidently, Akbar’s visionary pronouncements had grown no less flamboyant since he assured Jiji Anaka of his divine favour.

Still, for all the hyperbole and devotion of Abul Fazl’s defence, he wasn’t entirely off the mark. Akbar may not have spent much time at his books, but he was acquiring responsibility and ambition both. When he was six years old, just before Humayun besieged Kamran in Taligan, Akbar had been put in charge of Kabul, howsoever nominally, with his mother and a darogha to guide and serve him. Two years later, Kamran’s eight-year-old nephew was old enough, and a threat enough, to be imprisoned and taken into battle. When Humayun won, Akbar received his reward, like the other men on the battlefield: a village called Charkh to hold in fief. A year later, Akbar received his second fiefdom, inheriting all of Hindal’s territories in Ghazni, as also Hindal’s men.

The fiefs and men would mean nothing, of course, if Akbar treated them with the disdain he showed his studies. There is a wonderful story that reveals how Humayun, while keeping one eye on Akbar’s education, had another firmly focused on his son’s future relationships with the men who would be his to command one day. Among them was Munim Khan, whom Humayun had made Akbar’s *ataliq*, or guardian. It was a position of great trust and intimacy, so Munim had clearly redeemed himself for his inconstancy during Humayun’s exile.

Clearly also, Munim was an indulgent ataliq. Once, for instance, he gave Akbar the day off when the prince wanted, as ever, to give school a miss. Humayun heard about it, was upset and scolded Akbar. However, he didn’t tell the boy that it was his ataliq who had ratted him out, but put the blame on one Haji Muhammad instead. Later, Humayun would explain to Munim that he didn’t want Akbar, future padishah, to be prejudiced against him. Haji Muhammad, on the other hand, ‘was an impertinent person and deserved any harm that may come to him’.[56]

Given Humayun’s evident concern for his son’s well-being, present and